generations of historians. It would also be used by the British to understand a complex and foreign land. Among its many revelations was a new awareness, as pointed out by M. Athar Ali, of the geography of Hindustan as a peninsula lapped by the sea and crowned by the Himalayas. Abu'l Fazl described the people of the land in prose refreshingly free from the religious limitations of other medieval Muslim historians. 'The people of this country,' he wrote, 'are God-seeking, generous-hearted, friendly to strangers, pleasant-faced, of broad forehead, patrons of learning, lovers of asceticism, inclined to justice, contented, hard-working and efficient, true to salt, truth-seeing and attached to loyalty.' Despite being irritated by Raja Todar Mal's idol-worship, Abu'l Fazl wrote of the use of religious figures by Hindus in the following way:

> They one and all believe in the unity of God, and as to the reverence they pay to images of stone and wood and the like which simpletons regard as idolatry, it is not so. The writer of these pages has exhaustively discussed the subject with many enlightened and upright men and it became evident that these images of some chosen souls nearest in approach to the throne of God are fashioned as aids to fix the mind and keep the thoughts from wandering, while the worship of God alone is required as indispensable.

These views, which were also stated by Akbar, were in sharp contrast to Babur's dismayed recordings of his impression of Hindustan and its people: 'There is no beauty in its people, no graceful social intercourse, no poetic talent or understanding, no etiquette, nobility or manliness. The arts and crafts have no harmony or symmetry.'

The *Ain-i Akbari* reflected a determination on the part of the Padshah to delineate every aspect of life in the empire, from the mundane to the mystical. They included regulations for the tents in the farrash khana, instruction about etiquette to be followed in court, donations, education, marriages, the oiling of camels and the branding of horses. It is in just such a chapter that Abu'l Fazl also deals with the 'vexatious question' of the many women that Akbar had married, and the consequently unwieldy harem that had to be contained and sequestered. 'Several chaste women', we are reminded, guarded over each section of the harem which was further policed by eunuchs, Ahadis, and Rajput guards. The women were decorously involved in various duties and Abu'l Fazl would be careful to